

UPCOMING EVENT

## BEACON RETURNS IN 2025

*Connecting the Turfgrass Industry's Future*

Following the success of its 2024 debut, the BEACON program is returning this fall! This in-person BEACON Event is designed to connect emerging professionals with leaders across the turfgrass industry. BEACON brought together students and employers from nationally ranked golf courses, leading agrochemical companies, and other key sectors in its inaugural year.

We're excited to announce that BEACON 2025 will take place October 14-15 in Knoxville, Tennessee. Mark your calendars. This year promises to be even bigger and better. Additional details will be shared soon.

In 2025, we will be extending invitations to students from institutions across the region and focusing exclusively on those 18 and older. You can learn more about last year's event here:

<https://www.turfnet.com/news.html/uts-beacon-program-connects-dots-between-students-employers-university-research-2025/>

For business owners, TNLA members, or industry stakeholders—they can participate as company representatives at the event. This includes hosting a table at the career fair, engaging with students about internship or employment opportunities, and attending the evening networking reception. We welcome involvement from across the industry as we work to support workforce development.

For questions, please contact  
Dr. Becky Bowling at [rbowling@utk.edu](mailto:rbowling@utk.edu).

NEWS FROM TNLA

**Meet Dr. Chencheng Kang**  
Assistant Professor,  
Tennessee State University

I am excited to join Tennessee State University as an Assistant Professor in the Department of Agricultural Science and Engineering at the Otto L. Floyd Nursery Research Center in McMinnville. My research explores robotics, smart sensing, and AI-based systems that have the potential to transform nursery production practices in the future.

I earned my Ph.D. in Biological and Agricultural Engineering from Washington State University, where my research combined hyperspectral imaging and machine learning to improve vineyard irrigation management. Afterwards, I continued as a postdoctoral researcher at Penn State University, where I worked on robotic spraying systems, IoT-based crop monitoring, and computer vision applications for orchards and controlled environment agriculture.

At TSU, I plan to extend this work with a dedicated focus on nurseries. My research interests include precision and autonomous agricultural machinery—designing and evaluating intelligent systems that improve efficiency and sustainability; AI, computer vision, and field robotics—developing smart sensing and robotic solutions for crop monitoring and management; and modeling, simulation, and control of agricultural systems—creating data-driven models to optimize resource use and performance.

I look forward to collaborating with Tennessee's nursery industry, colleagues, and students to explore how these advanced technologies may be translated into practical options for future adoption.

Please feel free to reach me at [chang1@tnstate.edu](mailto:chang1@tnstate.edu), if you would like to connect.

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"ON A HALLOWED HILL IN TENNESSEE LIKE A BEACON SHINING BRIGHT THE STately WALLS OF OLD UT RISE GLORIOUS TO THE SIGHT"

UT Alma Mater

**BEACON 2025**

*Save the Date*  
**OCTOBER 14 & 15**  
STUDENTS | INDUSTRY | RESEARCH  
*Knoxville, TN*

- CAREER FAIR
- NETWORKING
- RESEARCH UPDATES

An event from the UT Turfgrass Program  
Questions? Contact Dr. Becky Bowling: [rbowling@utk.edu](mailto:rbowling@utk.edu)

## Tennessee Greentimes - Fall 2025

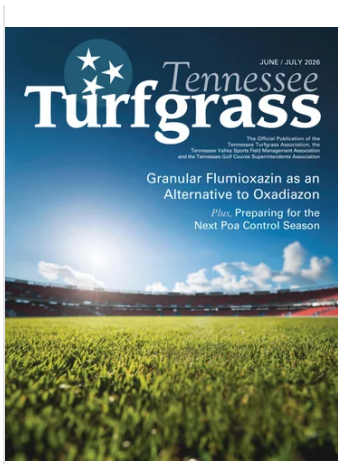
Published on Sep 15, 2025

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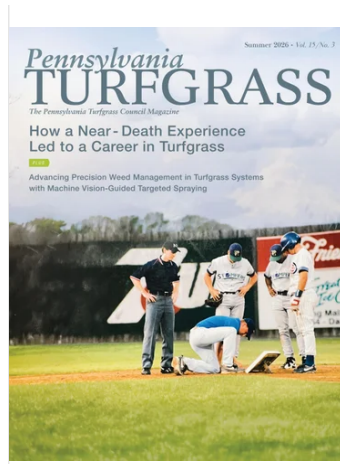
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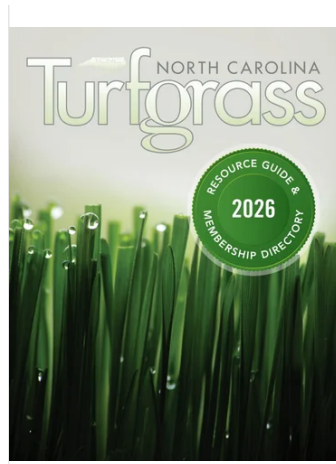
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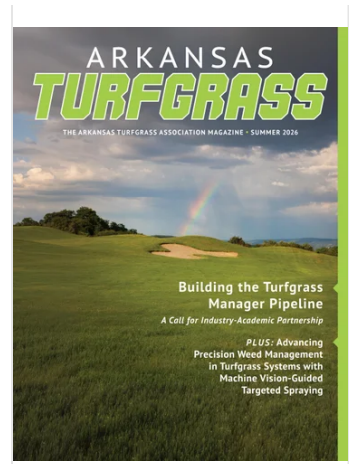
Tennessee Turfgrass - June / July 2026  
July 29, 2026



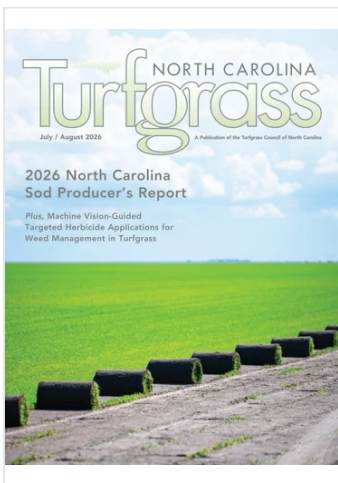
Pennsylvania Turfgrass - Summer 2026  
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North Carolina Turfgrass - 2026 Directory  
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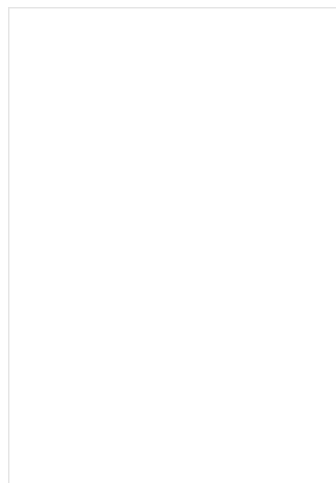


North Carolina Turfgrass - July / August 2026  
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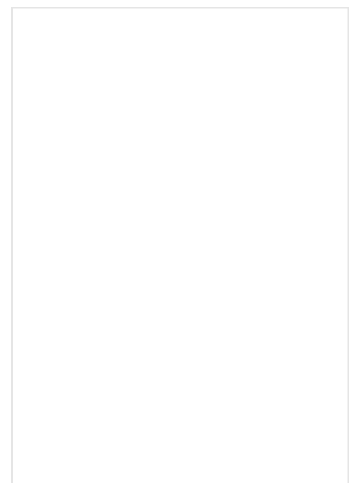


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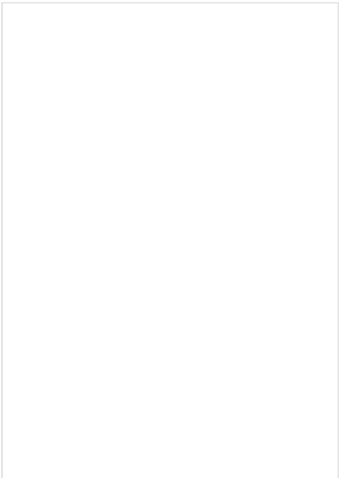
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